

Ministry Snapshot at a Glance

Pastor Enoch Liao · Boston Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC / CHCC) · Boston, Massachusetts

CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 · "The Evolving Chinese Church Around the Globe"

Who's speaking. The first of his family born in the US — parents born in China, raised in Taiwan, arriving as graduate students (the post-1965 wave). He is the lead English pastor at Boston BCEC (Chinatown roots, founded 1965, now with a suburban campus), 25+ years in ministry, at BCEC since 2001. Contributor to *Letter to the Asian American Church*; active in the Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative. BCEC is predominantly Chinese — but diverse across nearly every other axis: class, education, language, national origin, generation, politics. He speaks from the English-ministry vantage inside that congregation.

▪ Who Are the People? A century in one congregation.

Who sits in a US Chinese heritage church is inseparable from US immigration law:

- **1st wave — Gold Rush (late 1800s):** railroad builders and Chinatown founders who stayed when the 1882 Exclusion Act slammed the door. Their descendants are today's 3rd-, 4th-, even 5th-generation Chinese Americans — relationship to China *historical, not personal*.
- **2nd wave — post-1965 (Hart-Celler):** university-educated graduate students from Taiwan and the mainland. Enoch's family. "My parents were born in China and raised in Taiwan" — eleven words holding civil war, displacement, and a grad-school application.
- **3rd wave — Hong Kong (around the 1997 handover):** a Cantonese, Hong Kong-formed church culture, arriving into an ecosystem already shaped by two prior waves.
- **4th wave — mainland students (mid-2000s–early 2010s):** often here for a season, planning to return. They know it.

All four sit under one roof. A wealthy mainland student bound for Shanghai near a 4th-generation Chinese American who's never been to China. Not a problem to solve — the texture of the community he's been given.

▪ The Defining Tension: organizational fragility, and the exits it created.

The hardest tension isn't cultural or generational — it's **organizational**. Chinese heritage churches are extraordinarily complex (multiple languages, worship styles, pastoral teams, decision cultures) but built this complexity **without the organizational-development tools** — elder training, governance, staff formation — to sustain it. *Impressive in breadth, fragile in structure.*

That fragility opened two exits, both uniquely American:

- **MEMA/MARK churches — presented as Multi-Ethnic, Mostly Asian (MEMA), but in practice Mostly Asian, Really Korean (MARK).** Professionally resourced, organizationally legible, English-language evangelical experience — an **exit ramp from complexity**. Many Chinese Americans left. But it was never a place that *formed people in Chinese ethnic identity*.
- **The multiethnic church movement.** Enoch's critique is theological: the Revelation 6–7 "every nation, tribe, tongue" vision has been used to underwrite **majority-white-culture churches with minority hires and diverse faces**. That's not biblical diversity; it's majority culture with a different aesthetic. People feel the hollowness but can't name why.

Underneath it all: **geography and economics**. English-speaking young people leave for college and don't return — many Chinese heritage churches sit in expensive suburbs a 23-year-old on an entry-level salary can't afford. They find a church where they can afford to live, and it isn't a Chinese heritage church.

▪ What a Healthy Church Actually Forms

A **fourfold paradigm** — the Word of God, the People of God, the Spirit of God, the Mission of God — none subordinate to the others. What makes it distinctive here is what Enoch insists belongs *inside* it: **ethnic heritage**. "I don't think you're supposed to erase your background. I think you're supposed to bring them all — by the grace of God — into your identity in Christ."

So **ethnic identity formation is a discipleship necessity, not a cultural preference**. In regions where Chinese Americans are a small minority, internalized racial shame is a real pastoral issue that doesn't resolve by staying silent. The goal: disciples who are **whole, not hybrid**.

Model to watch: the English ministry at CCCRI (the only Chinese church in Rhode Island) — a **sending church**. Small numbers, but it forms people well and releases them carrying something durable. *A sending ministry is still a healthy ministry.*

▪ The Insight That Lands

The US has done this long enough to produce 4th- and 5th-generation believers — different in kind from the UK's first-generation BNO wave or the Nordics' two-generation community. What's genuinely **new** is an ethnic-revitalization impulse: young Chinese Americans **reclaiming their given Chinese names**, recovering what assimilation asked their parents to set aside. The Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative (Boston 2019; first National Ministers Collective, Houston 2023) is a bet that the answer isn't to redirect people to MEMA/MARK or multiethnic churches — but to **strengthen Chinese heritage churches from within**. For a growing number who want to be whole rather than hybrid, that may be exactly what they're looking for.